# Does corrective feedback improve second language speaking accuracy and fluency?

Corrective feedback consistently **improves speaking accuracy**, but its **impact on fluency is mixed.**

**Consensus Meter** N = 13




**Yes** 62% · **Possibly** 0% · **Mixed** 15% · **No** 23%

FIGURE 1 Scientific consensus on corrective feedback improving second language speaking accuracy and fluency

Empirical evidence consistently shows that oral corrective feedback improves grammatical and spoken accuracy across varied learning contexts ( Li & Hu, 2024; Nhac, 2021; Chu, 2011). In contrast, its impact on speaking fluency is complex: while peer interaction and structured feedback can facilitate proceduralization and temporal speed ( Sato & Lyster, 2012; Setiawan et al., 2025), immediate intrusive corrections frequently fail to enhance fluency or may induce conversational hesitation ( Yang, 2024; Tesnim, 2019; Zhu & Mokhtar, 2026).

## Corrective Feedback and Speaking Dimensions

| Evidence Strength | Claim |
|---|---|
| Strong | Oral corrective feedback reliably **enhances spoken accuracy**, grammatical precision, and phonological mastery across diverse classroom interventions ( Li & Hu, 2024; Nhac, 2021; Hamidi & Kazemian, 2022; Göksu & Uysal, 2026; Chu, 2011). |
| Moderate | Corrective feedback yields **inconsistent effects on fluency**, showing improvements during structured collaborative activities but no gains under immediate correction ( Yang, 2024; Sato & Lyster, 2012; Azad et al., 2018; Tesnim, 2019; Setiawan et al., 2025). |
| Moderate | Explicit corrections and prompts **maximize form noticing**, whereas implicit recasts and delayed delivery better preserve communicative flow ( Merlin, 2025; Noviarini & Prihatini, 2026; Nhac, 2021; Zhu & Mokhtar, 2026). |

FIGURE 2 Evidence strength ratings across accuracy, fluency, and delivery mechanisms of corrective feedback

### Impact on Spoken Accuracy

A substantial body of research establishes that oral corrective feedback acts as an effective pedagogical tool for refining spoken accuracy ( Li & Hu, 2024; Zhang et al., 2022; Göksu & Uysal, 2026). Feedback directs learners' focal attention to discrepancies between their current interlanguage and target language forms, promoting noticing and cognitive intake ( Li & Hu, 2024; Zhu & Mokhtar, 2026; Chu, 2011). In controlled experimental trials, adult learners receiving direct oral correction demonstrated significant gains in post-test accuracy compared to uncorrected controls ( Hamidi & Kazemian, 2022; Chu, 2011). These benefits span grammatical morphology, lexical choice, and pronunciation ( Nhac, 2021; Setiawan et al., 2025).

The exact delivery type influences the degree of accuracy development observed across learner cohorts ( Merlin, 2025; Chu, 2011; Basturkmen & Fu, 2021). Explicit corrections and metalinguistic feedback often slightly outperform purely implicit recasts in helping learners identify non-target forms ( Nhac, 2021; Göksu & Uysal, 2026). However, prompt-based strategies such as elicitations and clarification requests foster deeper self-repair and internal monitoring by pushing learners to produce modified output rather than passively receiving correct exemplars ( Sato & Lyster, 2012; Noviarini & Prihatini, 2026; Chu, 2011).

**Table 4.** Descriptive statistics of the groups' scores on speaking accuracy. (Li & Hu, 2024)

Learners themselves widely recognize the utility of feedback for linguistic precision, with surveys showing high openness to corrective intervention (Zhang et al., 2022; Lyster et al., 2012). Corrective interventions show particularly strong efficacy for intermediate and lower-proficiency learners who have greater scope for developmental gains (Chu, 2011). Furthermore, explicit focus-on-form techniques systematically enhance target feature mastery even among young EFL students ( Göksu & Uysal, 2026).

### Influence on Speaking Fluency and Trade-offs

In contrast to accuracy, the influence of corrective feedback on spoken fluency is heavily moderated by instructional delivery and social dynamics ( Li & Hu, 2024; Merlin, 2025; Basturkmen & Fu, 2021). In several classroom investigations, different feedback types produced negligible changes in temporal fluency, speech rates, or pause durations ( Yang, 2024; Azad et al., 2018; Zohrabi et al., 2017). Immediate teacher corrections delivered during continuous speaking tasks often fail to improve fluency because they interrupt discourse flow and provoke performance anxiety ( Tesnim, 2019; Zhu & Mokhtar, 2026).

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flowchart TD
    A[Oral Corrective Feedback] --> B[Delivery & Context Mode]
    B -->|Immediate Public Teacher Correction| C[Attentional Bottlenecks & Hesitation]
    C --> D[Accuracy Gains without Fluency Improvement]
    B -->|Structured Peer Interaction & Delayed Feedback| E[Repeated Production & Low-Anxiety Practic
    E --> F[Simultaneous Accuracy & Fluency Gains]
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When interventions successfully foster fluency alongside accuracy, they typically implement structured peer interaction or delayed, affect-sensitive feedback ( Sato & Lyster, 2012; Zhu & Mokhtar, 2026; Setiawan et al., 2025). Training students to provide peer corrections during conversational tasks allows learners to proceduralize grammatical rules while maintaining continuous speaking practice ( Sato & Lyster, 2012; Setiawan et al., 2025). Peer-mediated environments reduce speaking anxiety, which diminishes unnecessary pauses and supports smoother utterance construction ( Li & Hu, 2024; Setiawan et al., 2025).

Novel pedagogical frameworks, such as neuroscience-informed and delayed feedback strategies, similarly demonstrate that mitigating cognitive overload and emotional stress enables simultaneous improvements in speech rate and error-free clauses (Mehr et al., 2026; Hamidi & Kazemian, 2022). When task design protects the speaker's communicative momentum, corrective feedback can support both accuracy and fluency without enforcing an unavoidable performance trade-off ( Sato & Lyster, 2012; Mehr et al., 2026; Azad et al., 2018; Zohrabi et al., 2017).

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